served Munim's own household. Now, Akbar had made Muzaffar Khan his vizier, thus turning Munim's subordinate into his superior.[44]

Just as Asaf Khan disliked Muzaffar Khan's interference in his finances, so Munim Khan resented Muzaffar Khan's promotion in court – but this mutual animosity did not make Asaf and Munim allies, as it might have. Quite the opposite, in fact: Asaf Khan was actually being propped up *against* Munim by a non-Chagatai faction in Akbar's court. The grand parade of 5000 soldiers that Asaf Khan arranged was designed to impress Akbar and gain Asaf Khan command of the expedition against the Uzbeks, thus sidelining Munim, his ageing Chagatai chief.

The whole messy melting pot of rivalries came to a boil when Asaf Khan ran away. As Akbar railed against the 'Tajik dwarf', Munim Khan burst into tears, protesting that Asaf Khan's defection was not his fault: it was Khwaja Jahan – another one of Akbar's new recruits – who backed Asaf Khan as commander; and Khwaja Jahan who had been so terribly insulting of Munim's lineage, declaring that 'even a single hair of Asaf Khan is better than the entire Chagatai clan'.[45]

While Akbar consoled his weeping khan-khanan, Ali Quli Shaibani and his brother Bahadur were more productively engaged. They had crossed the Ganga into Bihar, and forged an alliance with Bengal's Afghan sultan, Sulaiman Karrani. Together, the sultan and the Uzbeks were besieging Rohtas when Akbar sent his envoy Qilich Khan to the fort, once again, to ensure its allegiance. With so many covetous glances turned in its direction, Rohtas decided to play its own game. Its lord, Fath Khan, let out that he was now Akbar's ally, at which Sulaiman Karrani – fearing a battle with the vast Mughal army – lost his nerve and abandoned his siege. Immediately, Fath Khan – 'who was nothing if not two-faced', grumbles Abul Fazl – stocked the fort with supplies and reneged on his promises of fealty to Akbar.

The Uzbeks, meanwhile, split forces. Bahadur and Sikander were to 'ravage and plunder' in Bihar,[46] possibly to keep the pressure on while Ali Quli launched the first in a series of negotiations with Akbar. He did so via his old friend Munim Khan.[47]

Between these two men, comrades-in-arms from Humayun's time, 'there was an old and warm friendship', writes Nizamuddin; and after several